consolidation of a key OBC bloc.

This is where Nitish's calculations also flow from. Choudhary could represent the other part of a duality that has been one of his most enduring political innovations—the 'Luv-Kush' social coalition. Nitish, a Kurmi, built a durable political identity by pairing his caste with the Koeris (Kushwahas), creating a non-Yadav OBC axis to counterbalance the Yadav-Muslim alliance. This 'Luv-Kush' formula was a vital bridge that also greatly empowered the BJP. It is not incognisant of that fact.

### THE RIGHT PAIRING

With Nitish's departure, the BJP-JD(U) coalition has to survive the absence of its architect while retaining his reach and durability. Choudhary offers a plausible answer. As a Kushwaha leader, he can anchor the Koeri side of the equation. If paired, as some in the JD(U) suggest, with Nitish's son Nishant Kumar, it can articulate the same social base in an undisturbed way.

**Takeaways**

- **Nitish backing and possible Koeri-Kurmi caste coalition give Samrat a boost**
- **The deputy CM's party-hopping past may be a damper. Also, the BJP leadership likes to spring last-minute surprises**

Choudhary's candidacy also rests on a related logic. Nitish, despite stepping aside, is unlikely to retreat from Bihar's political landscape. Any successor, then, would do well to be acceptable to him and his party. The BJP's challenge will be to assert leadership without alienating its ally. Choudhary could be that consensus figure—one who can bridge the NDA's internal dynamics. It's telling that, within the JD(U), the transition is being described not as a change of guard but as a "transfer of legacy". The question is, will the BJP repose full trust in a non-cadre face at such a decisive moment? ■

MAHARASHTRA

# Rumble in the Mahayuti Jungle

**Assault, defections, protests, all against each other... the ruling BJP-led alliance is having a time of it**







*By* **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

**ROUGHED UP** From top left, Rajya Sabha MP Nitin Patil (NCP) and ministers Shambhuraj Desai (Sena) and Makarand Patil (NCP)

### IF NOT FOR SUCH A THING

as an actual Opposition, you would sometimes be hard put to suss out where the enemy lines actually lie in Maharashtra. Check out the latest war report: a fracas during a local election saw two ministers and a Rajya Sabha MP being allegedly assaulted by the police, as two other ministers watched on. Of the victims, one was from the Shiv Sena (Eknath Shinde faction); the other two from the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), Ajit Pawar faction; the onlookers were from the BJP. That is, the three parties that share power in the state.

The arrest of self-styled godman Ashok Kharat, similarly, exacted blood from the NCP, with the state women's commission chief being scalped and the state president under a cloud. It was this latent animosity between the ruling triumvirate that got physical in Satara, during the recent local body polls. Even if you put it down to local-level competition, it was proof, all over again, that the ruling Mahayuti alliance is a very unruly fissile compound all around.

The BJP was in a grudge match with the Sena-NCP for the Satara zilla parishad (ZP) chief's post. The latter had an edge with 35 members; the BJP had only 28. Things got so heated that both fronts sequestered their members to prevent poaching! The son of NCP ZP member Bapusaheb Shinde still lodged a police complaint alleging his father had been kidnapped.

On election day, March 20, high-voltage drama erupted as tourism minister Shambhuraj Desai (Sena), relief and rehabilitation minister Makarand Patil and Rajya Sabha MP Nitin Patil (both NCP) were 'manhandled' by the police in the parishad building. The police